

Guatemala

Once the hub of the Mayan civilization, modern Guatemala is Central America's largest and most populated country, and has the biggest manufacturing sector. Guatemalan factories produce foods, textiles, paper, pharmaceuticals, and rubber goods. Plantations in the south grow coffee, bananas, cotton, and sugar-cane for export.

Farming

About half of Guatemala's people are of Mayan descent. Most live in the western highlands, growing crops and rearing animals, which they trade at local markets. People from distant hamlets use weekly markets as a chance to socialize and keep abreast of local news.



Tikal

Tourism is a growing industry in Guatemala, and each year about 500,000 people visit the country's Mayan ruins. Tikal, once a great Mayan city, was founded in about 600 BC and flourished until about AD 890, when it was suddenly deserted. The city once had about 40,000 inhabitants.

GUATEMALA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Guatemala City
AREA	108,890 sq km (42,043 sq miles)
POPULATION	11,400,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, Quiché, Mam, Kekchí, Cakchiquel
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Quetzal



Honduras

A small, poor country, Honduras relied for many years on bananas and timber as its main sources of income. However, since the banana industry was devastated by Hurricane Mitch in 1998, coffee, flowers, and fruit now supply the country's income. Unemployment is high, and most people live in small villages.



HONDURAS FACTS

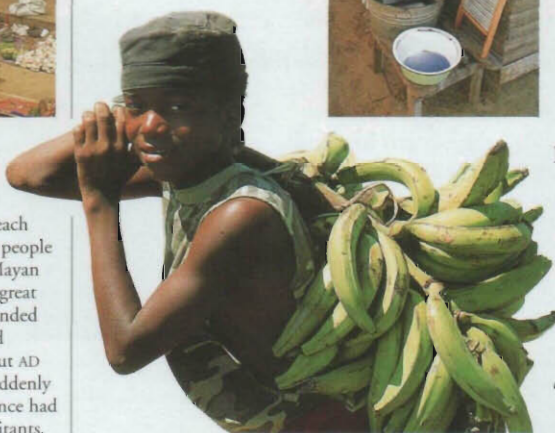
CAPITAL CITY	Tegucigalpa
AREA	112,090 sq km (43,278 sq miles)
POPULATION	6,350,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Spanish, English Creole, Garifuna
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Lempira

People

About 90 per cent of Hondurans are *mestizos*, of mixed European and Native American descent. Along the Caribbean coast are settlements of the Garifuna, descendants of black slaves who swam ashore more than 350 years ago when slave ships from Nigeria were shipwrecked off the Honduran coast.

Hurricane Mitch

The vast banana plantations in the northeast of the Honduras were wiped out by Hurricane Mitch in 1998. The storms caused £2 million (\$3 billion) worth of damage and the deaths of 5,600 people. Bananas comprised 40 per cent of the country's exports, but have been replaced by coffee, shrimp, and melon.



El Salvador

The smallest country in Central America, El Salvador has a rugged landscape that includes more than 20 volcanoes. A thick layer of volcanic ash and lava provide ideal conditions for growing coffee. Economically, El Salvador is still recovering from a civil war that raged between 1979 and 1992 and major earthquakes in 2001.



EL SALVADOR FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	San Salvador
AREA	21,040 sq km (8,124 sq miles)
POPULATION	6,300,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Spanish
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Colón and US dollar



People

El Salvador is Central America's most densely populated country. There are about 304 people per sq km (788 per sq mile) and the population is growing at about two-and-a-half per cent a year. Almost 90 per cent are *mestizos*, and three-quarters are Roman Catholics. More than one-third are farmers who scrape a living in the highlands.

Deforestation

Today, only about five per cent of El Salvador is still forested. Vast tracts of forest, including cedar, oak, and mahogany, have been felled for export and to clear land for farming cash crops such as coffee.

Belize

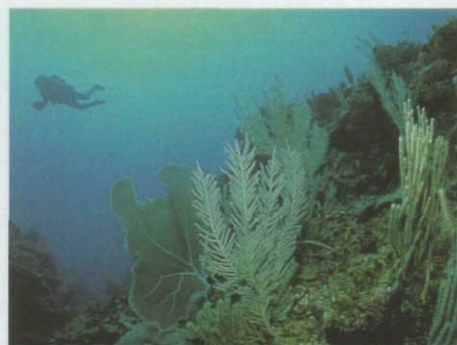
As most of Belize is dense rainforest, most of its small population live along the Caribbean coast. The two largest groups are the *mestizos* and Creoles, who also have African blood, and are descended from black slaves who were marooned in Belize in the 17th century.

Barrier reef

Protecting Belize's swampy coastal plains from flooding is the world's second largest barrier reef, 290 km (190 miles) long. The reef supports a wide variety of colourful fish.

BELIZE FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Belmopan
AREA	22,960 sq km (8,865 sq miles)
POPULATION	200,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	English, English Creole, Spanish, Maya, Garifuna
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Belizean dollar



Belmopan

Belize City, the country's chief port, was the capital for many years. In 1960, a hurricane and tidal wave caused severe damage, so in 1970, a new capital, Belmopan, was built in the centre of the country, far from coastal storms. Its population is only 4,000, mostly civil servants.

